The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Reuters

The White House said **Steve Witkoff** and **Jared Kushner**, two of Donald Trump's top envoys, would meet **Iranian** officials in Islamabad on Saturday. Abbas Araghchi, Iran's foreign minister, arrived in Pakistan's capital, but Iran's foreign ministry said he would be meeting only "Pakistani high-level officials". Mr Trump has insisted on maintaining a naval blockade of Iranian ports and shipping until Iran makes a deal.

America's **s&p 500** and NASDAQ indexes closed at record highs on Friday, rising by 0.8% and 1.6% respectively. Both were boosted by hopes of talks to end the Iran war, and by a surge in **Intel's** shares. The American chipmaker's stocks rose by 24% on Friday, up to a record high, after it posted strong first-quarter revenues of $13.6bn.

Fighting between **Israel** and **Hizbullah** intensified a day after Mr Trump announced that a ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon would be extended for three weeks. Israel launched air strikes in southern Lebanon after issuing evacuation warnings, while Hizbullah said it fired rockets and drones at Israeli forces. The militant group said the ceasefire was "meaningless".

America's **Department of Justice** dropped its criminal probe into **Jerome Powell**. The decision removes a major obstacle for Kevin Warsh, Donald Trump's pick, to succeed him as chair of the Federal Reserve. A Republican senator had promised to hold up his nomination while the investigation was under way, arguing it interfered with the central bank's independence.

Google agreed to invest up to $40bn in **Anthropic**, including an initial $10bn, in a huge funding deal for the AI lab. The deal values the company at about $350bn and reflects the vast spending needed to build and run advanced AI systems. Google already supplies Anthropic with chips and cloud services, even as it develops its own competing models.

Britain said the **Falkland Islands'** sovereignty was "not in question" following reports that America may reconsider its diplomatic backing for Britain's claim. The idea appeared in a leaked Pentagon email outlining ways to punish NATO allies that refused to support strikes on Iran. Argentina's president, Javier Milei, said this week he would do "everything humanly possible" to return the islands to Argentine control.

America's Space Force awarded contracts worth up to $3.2bn to 12 companies to develop space-based missile interceptors, part of Mr Trump's "Golden Dome" defence plan. The idea is to place systems in orbit that can spot and hit missiles soon after they are launched, rather than waiting to intercept them later using ground-based defences.

Word of the week: *Kriegstüchtig*, a German term for "war-readiness", coined by Boris Pistorius, Germany's defence minister. Read more about how the country's armed forces are getting battle-ready.

Photograph: Getty Images

Ukraine’s position improves

After months of uncertainty, Ukraine has received positive news. The defeat of Viktor Orban, Hungary’s populist leader, in elections this month, helped unlock a long-promised €90bn ($105bn) loan from the European Union that he had obstructed. The loan is interest-free and will be paid back only if Russia stumps up reparations after the war.

Things are going better on the battlefield too. In March Russia suffered record casualties of 35,000 as its spring offensive largely stalled. Ukraine now out-produces Russia in drones and has perfected its ability to hit supply lines and troop convoys behind front lines. Its expanding deep-strike campaign, focused on oil terminals and refineries, has cut Russian crude exports by at least 40% and forced Russia to reduce output by up to 400,000 barrels a day, according to Reuters. Still, although pressure on Vladimir Putin is rising, Russia’s president shows little interest in negotiations or lasting peace.

Photograph: Getty Images

The Donald comes for dinner

Politicos like to quip that Donald Trump's "villain origin story" began at the 2011 White House Correspondents' Dinner. Attending as a guest, the host of "The Apprentice" sat stewing at his table while President Barack Obama lobbed zingers his way. Mr Trump never quite shrugged off the humiliation: he has boycotted the event throughout his years in office. But on Saturday Mr Trump will attend the black-tie event for his first time as president and deliver the keynote speech.

As awkward dinners go, it is likely to give Thanksgiving a run for its money. The event, organised by the White House Press Association, is billed as a celebration of journalism and the First Amendment. The president will spend the evening hobnobbing with, in his words, "the enemy of the people". News organisations the president has sued are expected to attend. Many have urged the event's organisers to demonstrate opposition to Mr Trump's attacks on the press. Expect a spicy dinner.

Photograph: Getty Images

Saudi Arabia’s football splurge on display in Asia

Saudi Arabia’s push into football has been swift and expensive. The country’s sovereign-wealth vehicle, the Public Investment Fund, has spent heavily to raise the profile of its domestic league and project influence abroad. Saudi Arabia has secured the right to host the 2034 FIFA World Cup, and an influx of elite players from Europe has lifted the standard of competitions at home.

The impact is now visible on the pitch. Saudi clubs have become dominant in Asia: last year three of the four semi-finalists in the AFC Champions League Elite, Asia’s top club competition, were Saudi. This season’s final, which will take place in Jeddah on Saturday, will pit Japan’s Machida Zelvia against Al-Ahli. The Saudi team has been powered by high-profile signings, including Franck Kessié and Ivan Toney.

But the model behind the surge is changing. The government is reining in spending, so clubs will soon need to generate income or find new backers.

Photograph: Craig Busch

Eeyore’s big day in Austin

On the last Saturday of April, Austin, Texas celebrates Eeyore’s birthday with a day-long party in a park. There is face-painting, flower crowns, drum circles and costumes. The tradition began in 1964, when literature students at the University of Texas wanted an excuse for a pre-exam party.

They chose to honour one of literature’s most beloved pessimists, who, in A.A. Milne’s “Winnie-the-Pooh” book, bemoaned the lack of gifts and festivities on his own birthday (date unspecified, but “it was a warm day”). His friends in the Hundred Acre Wood attempt to put things right, with more enthusiasm than success.

The celebration honours Austin’s past: it may now be a burgeoning, expensive, overcrowded tech hub, but was once a hippie haven; “Keep Austin Weird” remains the city’s unofficial slogan. The party also nods to a familiar type: the gloomy but loyal friend. Eeyore may be melancholic, but he is steady, honest and kind—qualities worth celebrating.

Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: keeping up with the Castros

Cuba is not the main target for the United States' gunboat diplomacy. It lacks Venezuela's oil wealth, or Iran's nuclear threat. But Donald Trump and Marco Rubio, his Cuban-American secretary of state, are focused on it nonetheless, partly because the island is on their doorstep. They hope to weaken, if not break, the repressive Communist regime and in January imposed an oil blockade, worsening an economic crisis. That has empowered a younger generation of the Castro family, the dynasty that has held sway since Fidel seized power in 1959.

Miguel Díaz-Canel has been president of Cuba since 2018. But veto power is still held by his predecessor, Raúl Castro, Fidel's 94-year-old brother. And now a new generation is gaining clout: Raúl Guillermo Rodríguez Castro, Raúl's 41-year-old grandson; Alejandro Castro Espín, his 60-year-old son; and Óscar Pérez-Oliva Fraga, Fidel's 55-year-old great-nephew.

Until recently, Mr Rodríguez Castro was best known for his playboy antics. In contrast to his impoverished countrymen, he is often pictured on luxury yachts and private jets. He is known as "Raúlito" or "El Cangrejo" (the crab), because he has an extra finger. He does not hold a senior position in the government or the communist party. But in February he reportedly held secret talks with Mr Rubio, who may see the young, influential Cuban as someone who could be a useful ally after regime change.

Meanwhile Mr Castro Espín, a colonel in the armed forces, sits close to the heart of Cuba's security state. Many see him as an important power broker. Known as "El Tuerto" (the one-eyed man) after he partially lost his sight in an accident, he led secret talks with the Obama administration that briefly opened relations in the mid-2010s. Now he is reportedly once again involved in backchannel discussions.

Mr Fraga is the least well-known of the trio, but may prove the most consequential. An economic bureaucrat, he rose through the military's business arm before entering government, and has quickly accumulated titles: minister of foreign trade and investment, deputy prime minister and member of the national assembly—positions that make him eligible for the presidency. In March he appeared on television to announce that Cubans abroad would be allowed to own businesses and invest in infrastructure on the island. Many in Havana see him as the most plausible next president.

The United States' pressure on Cuba may result in a more pliable regime. But rather than ending Castro rule, Mr Trump's policy also risks entrenching it in a new, messier way: sharing power among heirs rather than concentrating it in one.

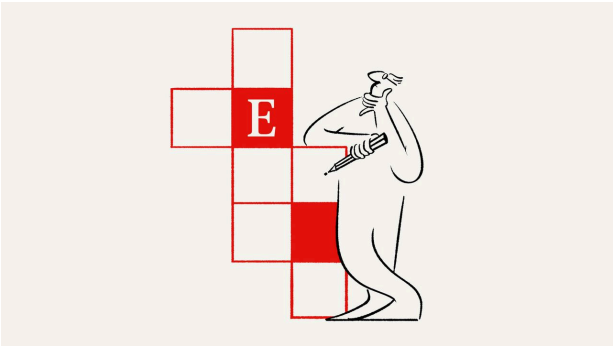

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - A maths puzzle takes one's breath away (6)

2 across - Dry garden tool snipping off rose head (5)

3 across - Former lover gently touches those who've left home (6)

1 down - Mark of possession is absurd to a shopper (10)

Straight clues

1 across - Condition characterised by a shortness of breath (6)

2 across - What dries as it gets wetter (5)

3 across - People living and working abroad (6)

4 down - Its missing from this sentence (10)

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Amitava Mukerjee, Danville, California, America

Ahmed Alsuwaidi, Dubai, UAE

Claudine Provencher, Cavillon, France

They gave the correct answers of Vitus Bering, Gibraltar, Ferdinand Magellan, Malacca and Hormuz. The theme is famous straits: Bering, Gibraltar, Magellan, Malacca and Hormuz.

The questions were:

Monday: Which Danish explorer spent many years leading expeditions for the Russian navy in the 18th century?

Tuesday: Which port and naval base was ceded to Britain by Spain in the 1713 Treaty of Utrecht?

Wednesday: Which Portuguese explorer was the first European to cross the Pacific?

Thursday: Which Malaysian state is bordered by Negeri Sembilan to the north and Johor to the east?

Friday: Which medieval kingdom in the Persian gulf was ruled by descendants of Muhammad Diramku?

A nation of sheep will beget a government of wolves.

Edward Murrow